well-founded, but eventually the same confidence that had seen him hold firm with Stringfellow asserted itself.

A Bank is Born

Sorabji and his friend Kalianji applied themselves energetically to the many tasks which setting up a new bank demanded. They rented some old premises in Gresham Building at ₹600 per month. This was done through the good offices of S.N. Vicaji, former cashier of the Eastern Bank, who agreed to join them as Chief Cashier on a salary of ₹500 per month. Now there were three of them and they addressed the matter of finding suitable Directors after the heavyweights of the financial world had turned them down. They approached some of the lesser-known businessmen of the day and those who agreed to serve as Directors included Ardeshir B. Dubash, Munchershaw F. Khan, M.J. Varadhman, Mulji Haridas, Motilal Kanji, Jamsetji H. Chothia, Radhakison Lakmichand, and Haji Dawood Haji Elias. Kalianji who had provided all the preliminary expenses was also appointed as a Director.

The bigger challenge lay in finding a suitable personality to become the Chairman—a person who would inspire confidence in the bank at a time when psychological factors were of great relevance and importance. But just as they had finished framing the Memorandum and Articles of Association, (and the appointment of a suitable Chairman was agitating their minds), there came the news that the Bank of Burma had failed, causing heavy losses. The failure could not have come at a worse time but there was no question of giving up. Sorabji's analysis of the reasons for the failure of the Bank of Burma revealed a shortcoming which is relevant to this day: a failure to be transparent in its dealings and the absence of a constant disclosure of what the bank was doing.

But despite the unfavourable climate, prejudices, and the young age of the Bank's sponsors, subscriptions came relatively easily, something which could be ascribed to Sorabji's ebullient personality and the gathering strength of the Swadeshi movement at the time. The Central Bank had an authorized capital of ₹50 lakhs divided into shares of ₹50, while its subscribed capital was ₹20 lakhs of which one half was paid-up. H.T. Parekh's father, Thakoredas, who was with Sorabji at the Bank of India left